

Energy Sigma

Staying put on \$100/b for 2026 and initiating 2027 Brent at \$88/b

Our 2026 and 2027 price forecasts for Brent at \$100/b and \$88/b, respectively, are \$9/b and \$7/b ahead of the forwards curve at the time of writing.

- We update our baseline balances forecast assuming freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz is restored by the end of this month. We stay put on our \$100/b forecast for Brent in 2026 and initiate 2027 at \$88/b on average.
- If the timeline of the Strait normalization gets pushed out to the end of July, we would expect Brent to average \$105/b in 2026 and \$95/b in 2027. On the other hand, if it gets pushed out to the end of August, we would expect Brent to average \$110/b in 2026 and \$105/b in 2027.

In late March, we thought that if the Strait remained closed through the end of May, 2026 Brent would reprice to \$110/b. May is behind us but the forwards-implied 2026 Brent stood at \$91/b at the time of writing. We maintain our forecast for Brent to average \$100/b in 2026 and expect it to average \$88/b in 2027, assuming the freedom of navigation through the Strait is restored by the end of this month.

The Strait remains largely closed but managed money positioning has retreated back to pre-war levels (Figure 1), and so has implied volatility (Figure 2). We interpret this as [fundamentals having grown into the initial hype over time](#), albeit at a slower pace than we initially expected, and the lack of conviction among market participants about how long the current situation could persist.

Commodities Research

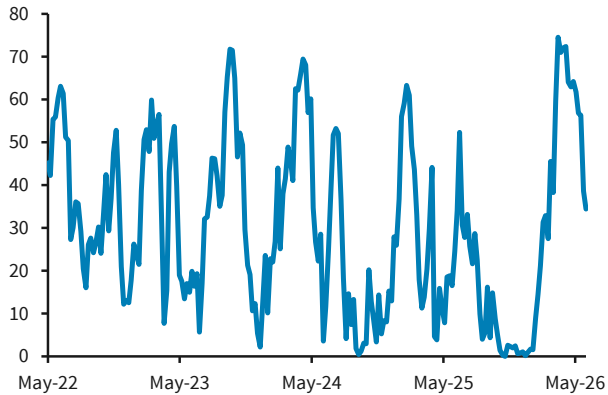
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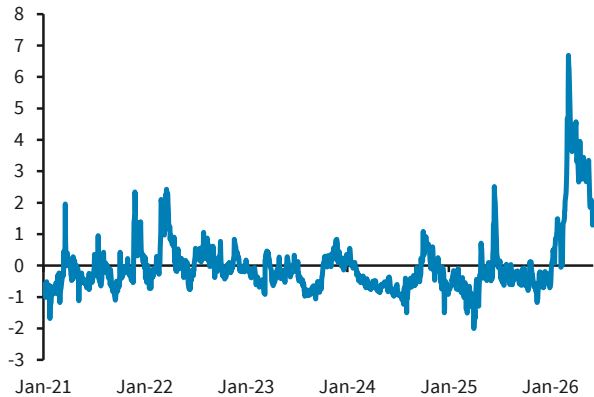
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BCI, US

 Oil Balances 8 June 2026

FIGURE 1. Managed money positioning in oil is back to pre-war levels...

Note: Net speculative positioning in Brent and WTI futures and options combined, percentile rank based on data since 2014.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ...so is excess implied vol in oil markets

Note: OVX minus VIX in standard deviation from mean since 2020
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

We reiterate that this is not a new equilibrium. The Strait cannot remain closed in perpetuity with oil prices at \$100/b. Oil inventories continue to draw down, although the pace has not accelerated to the extent we expected. Our global total oil inventory indicator suggests that adjusted for seasonality, observed inventories have been declining at 4.5 mb/d over the past eight weeks ([Figure 3](#)).

FIGURE 3. Observed inventories continue to decline at ~4.5 mb/d...

Note: Our weekly global total oil inventory indicator excluding the Middle East Gulf region minus the pre-pandemic seasonal average (2017-19), mb
Source: Kpler, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. ...but the pace has not accelerated because of the pull back in Chinese demand

Note: Chinese oil demand and the long-term trend, mb/d
Source: GACC, NBS, Kpler, Barclays Research

Adjusted for the historical beta between observed inventory draws and estimated imbalance, recent inventory trends imply that the market is currently running a 7 mb/d deficit, which is largely in line with our latest bottom-up supply-demand estimates (see attached). If the timeline for the freedom of navigation through the Strait being restored shifts to July-end, we would expect Brent to average \$105/b and \$95/b in 2026 and 2027, respectively. In a more

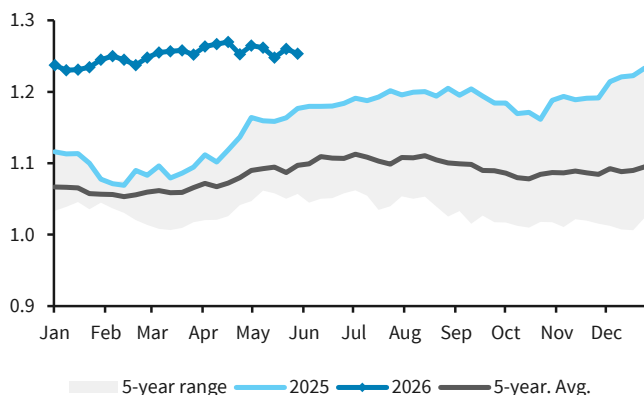
extended scenario in which the Strait does not normalize until the end of August, we would expect Brent to average \$110/b and \$105/b in 2026 and 2027, respectively.

The biggest surprise relative to the [scenarios we laid out in late-March](#) has been a sharp decline in Chinese oil demand ([Figure 4](#)). In April, China's oil demand was down 12% y/y but was still up 2% y/y for the first four months of 2026. Most market participants have interpreted this as the price elasticity of demand in China being much higher than anticipated, but these are extraordinary times and therefore the divergence between steady-state and observed demand elasticity should be studied with caution and in conjunction with the lagged activity indicators.

Visible inventories in China are largely unchanged since the Iran war began ([Figure 5](#)), while they have been declining at a rapid pace everywhere else. Could the country be conserving supplies for a scenario in which this impasse continues for much longer than most expect? It is hard to prove but probably easier than attributing the recent weakness in demand to an abrupt increase in energy efficiency given the country's oil demand has been growing at a steady pace over the past several years despite growing electrification of the vehicle fleet.

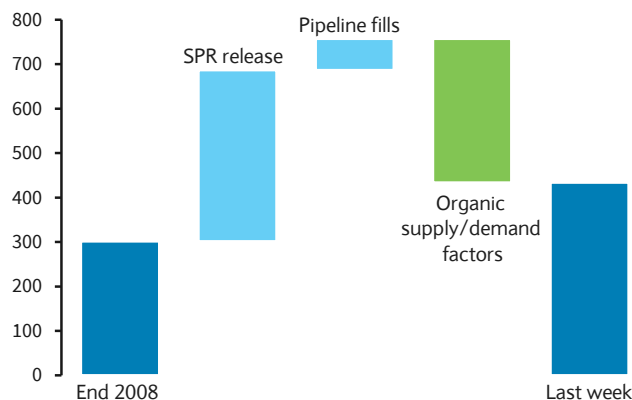
The obvious question would be why such caution? Oil prices have done nothing for years and there will certainly be a glut after the Strait reopens. Our own balances show a large surplus for 2027 based on the assumption that the freedom of navigation through the Strait is restored by the end of this month.

FIGURE 5. China's crude oil inventories are largely unchanged so far this year



Note: China's crude oil inventories, bb
Source: Kpler, Barclays Research

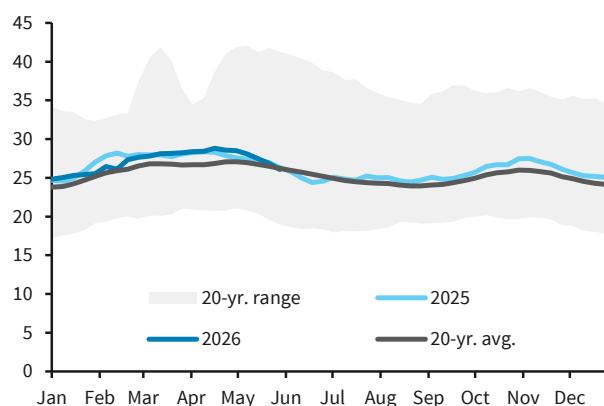
FIGURE 6. US commercial crude oil inventories have been tightening under the surface



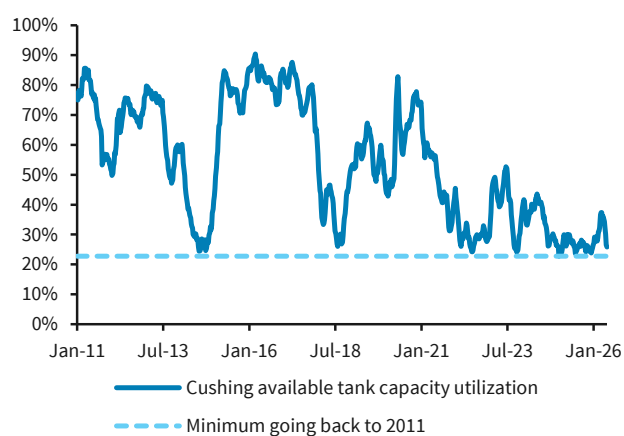
Note: Change in US commercial crude oil inventories since 2008, mb
Source: EIA, Barclays Research

The flip side is that in the US, which has driven a large majority of all supply growth for the past several years, commercial crude oil inventories, adjusted for the decline in SPR and the increase in pipeline fills, have declined by 323 mb since 2008. For perspective, commercial crude oil inventories stood at 301 mb at the end of 2008 ([Figure 6](#)).

At the recent pace, commercial crude oil inventories in the US in days of refining demand ([Figure 7](#)), adjusted for the increase in pipeline fills to accommodate growth in production, would breach the 20-year minimum in eight to ten weeks, and storage capacity utilization at Cushing, OK, the pricing hub for WTI, is within sight of the lowest level since 2010 ([Figure 8](#)). Last, even with the UAE fully utilizing its spare capacity, we still see demand growth outpacing non-OPEC supply growth in 2027.

FIGURE 7. US crude oil inventories are tighter than they appear

Note: US commercial crude oil inventories in days of refining demand
Source: EIA, Barclays Research

FIGURE 8. Cushing storage utilization has been declining fast

Source: EIA, Barclays Research

FIGURE 9. Our \$100/b forecast for Brent this year is significantly ahead of the forward curve

Barclays oil price forecast (\$/b)	2025	2026 Q1	2026 Q2	2026 Q3	2026 Q4	2026	2027 Q1	2027 Q2	2027 Q3	2027 Q4	2027
Brent	68	79	115	105	100	100	95	90	85	80	88
WTI	65	73	102	98	95	92	92	87	83	77	85
WTI-Brent (S:ENCO 1-1)	-3.4	-6.1	-13.0	-7.0	-5.0	-7.8	-3.0	-3.0	-2.0	-3.0	-2.8
Brent (vs curve)			15	15	14	8		9	5	1	7
Brent (vs consensus)			15	14	15	14		n/a	n/a	n/a	13
WTI (vs curve)			5	12	14	6		11	8	3	9
WTI (vs consensus)			7	17	17	11		n/a	n/a	n/a	13

Note: Curve and consensus estimates as of 9 June 2026.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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